

Species: PURPLE FINCH

(Vernacular Name)

Carpodacus purpureus

(Scientific Name-use binomial)

Date(s): February 29, 1976

Time Bird Seen: 8:35 A.M. to 8:40 A.M. - MST

Locality: Chataqua Park (Bluebell Canyon)

Nearest Town: Boulder

County: Boulder

Other observers who independently identified this bird:

NAME

ADDRESS

TELEPHONE

None

Optical Equipment: 10X50 Bushnell Binoculars

If photographed, type of equipment used:

Light Conditions: Overcast, gray; snow flurries.

Distance from bird (how measured): 25 feet (paced off).

Number of Birds Seen: One Sex: Female Plumage: Adult

Describe the bird's overall behavior and demeanor:

Observed feeding on ground with a half dozen Gray-headed Juncos. Flew into heavy underbrush with the approach of an adult Goshawk.

Describe in great detail the bird's size, overall shape, plumage and color-pattern. Include details on shape of bill, wings and tail. Give particular emphasis to the marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance in field guide descriptions is not enough. Describe what you actually saw in the field:

An obvious finch; small (5 1/2"-6") brownish, heavily streaked on breast. Conical shaped, pale colored beak. Heavy, prominent, dark jaw stripe. Conspicuous whitish eyeline. Strongly marked brownish facial-ear patch. Heavily streaked (blurry appearing), brownish breast markings extending from upper breast to, but not through undertail coverts. Undertail coverts whitish, clearly unmarked. Back (faintly streaked) and upper tail, brownish. Wings, brownish with two faint wing bars. Tail, notched.

Describe the bird's song or call, if heard, including method of delivery, i.e., from perch, in flight, etc:

None heard.

Describe the habitat in which you observed this bird:

Foothills canyon - scrub oak, occasional cottonwoods, thickets

How were similarly appearing species eliminated?

Cassin's Finch (♀): Facial markings much less prominent, particularly jaw stripe and facial patch. Breast markings, noticeably finer and much clearer (not blurry effect of Purple Finch). Undertail coverts faintly marked. On preceding day I had the opportunity to study Cassin's Finches for over 30 minutes at a feeder in Georgetown, some through a telescope from about 75' as they perched in low bushes. It was easy to pick out the marked undertail coverts on both males and females. Also apparent was the well defined, sharp breast markings on the females. The Purple Finch seen on the following day was decidedly a different appearing bird.

House Finch (♀): Lacks bold facial and head markings (rather nondescript head).

Prior experience with this and similarly appearing species:

Have seen numerous Purple Finches in Illinois and New York over the years. Experienced with Cassin's Finches from Washington and Colorado since 1961. Considerable experience with House Finches throughout west and New York City area.

Books, illustrations and advice consulted and how did these influence this documentation?

Birds of North America, Robbins

"Identification of Purple and Cassin's Finches", Remsen (CFO Journal).

This report was written from notes made during X after X observation; from memory

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